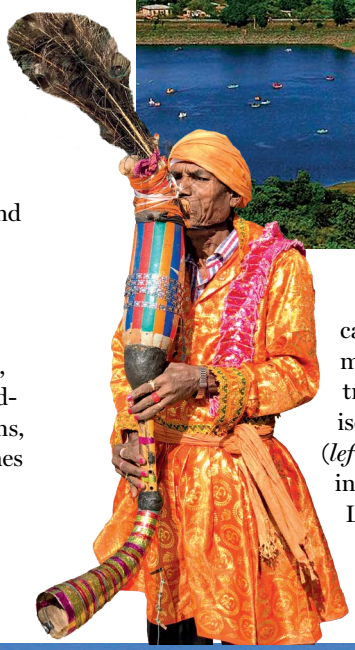

Aakar Lords Inn Saputara, overlooking the lake

Saputara, Gujarat

Gujarat's only hill station, Saputara lies in the hilly Dang district on the Maharashtra border. Saputara means 'Abode of the Snake'; the Sarpaganga river originates here and the animist tribes worship stone totems and *Saputara no sap*, a snake sculpture on its banks. About 94 per cent of Dang's 200,000 population is tribal, mostly Bhils, Kunbis, Kuknas, Varli, Nayaka, Kotwaliya and Kathodiya. At 1,000 m, Saputara has all the trappings of a modest hill station—lake, tableland, gardens, waterfall, ropeway, church, a few shrines and scenic lookouts like Echo Point, Sunrise Point and Sunset Point. The Saputara Tribal Museum has galleries on terracotta figures, jewellery, musical instruments, tools, paintings, masks and dioramas of various tribes. Gujarat Tourism organises a Saputara monsoon festival (*left*) and a paragliding festival in December. Stay at Aakar Lords Inn Saputara (Rs 7,500; 7377734777, *www.lordshotels.com*) overlooking the lake.



Getting there: 70 km from Nashik airport; 52 km from Waghai, the nearest railway station





Tawang, Arunachal Pradesh

Arunachal's hot new circuit is the 14th Dalai Lama's exile trail marking his dramatic escape across the Himalayas from Lhasa to the northeastern state in 1959. The route traverses Chu-Dhang-Mo, Gorzam, Shardi, Lumla-Tse, Thonglek, Tawang, Dirang, Bomdila to Tezpur from where he departed for Mussoorie by train and set up the Tibetan Government in exile at Dharamsala. Nearly 80,000 Tibetan exiles followed his path to safety. All the places along the epic walking trail have stone markers outlining the journey in Bodhi/English. The Mandala India Vision Festival in November at the serene Mandala Pass (3,200 m), 30 km from Dirang, showcases spiritual, folk and modern music of India. In Tawang, stay at the swank new boutique resort Timilo and try local delicacies at their fine-dine restaurant O-Shum (Rs 15,000; 8532958233, 9233318910, *www.timiloboutique.com*).

Getting there: Fly to Tezpur from Kolkata or Guwahati and drive 143 km to Tawang

(Top) A room at Timilo, and its fine-dine restaurant O-Shum, (right) the Tawang Monastery

